While living in Madras, Kamaladevi came into contact with the vibrant Chattopadhyay family, whose members included the poet and Congress leader Sarojini Naidu, Communist party leader Suhasini Chattopadhyay and the poet Harindranath Chattopadhyay. She married Harindranath in a civil ceremony in 1919 and followed him to Cambridge; the marriage eventually ended in divorce.



In England, Chattopadhyay pursued a diploma in social work, which took her to the slums and alleys of London's notorious East End. Here, she would mix with people from diverse social backgrounds and gain a good grounding in the practical aspects of social work.

Leading women forward

Chattopadhyay followed in the tradition of her mother and grandmother, both educated women who were unafraid to defy social convention. In the 1920s she was the first woman to contest in a legislative assembly election in India. She lost by a narrow margin. Soon after, she was appointed General Secretary of the All India Women's Conference, the organization set up to expand educational opportunities for women. She also joined the Congress, and was among the first women to participate in the civil disobedience movement (and be arrested for it). She led from the front, and her example encouraged many more women across class lines to take to the streets and march for freedom.